ABYSSAL: THE LAST HORIZON

Pre-Production Document • Narrative, World, Systems and Production Framework

OPEN-WORLD UNDERWATER RPG

Concept version 1.0 • Vision and story framework • October 2026

This is a pre-production proposal. Playtime, regions, and content counts are design targets, not a validated production promise. An RPG offering 300 hours per campaign requires modular production, extensive testing, and a matching budget.

CONCEPT DOCUMENT • NOT A FINAL PRODUCTION SCRIPT

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01. High concept

Premise

ABYSSAL is an open-world action RPG and exploration game set entirely beneath the ocean’s surface. The player creates a recovery diver hired to locate the missing research vessel Orpheus in a restricted zone. The mission reveals signs of a non-human civilization, a colossal geological prison, and an entity known as the Original Leviathan. The central mystery is not merely what is imprisoned, but who built the prison, why it was built, and which versions of history were deliberately falsified.

Player fantasy

Become an explorer capable of crossing hostile environments, building a crew, negotiating with rival powers, uncovering contradictory truths, and leaving historical consequences behind. The player does not select an abstract alignment; they make local decisions that reshape power, ecology, collective memory, and the endings available.

Design pillars

1) A vertical ocean world where depth is spatial and narrative progression. 2) Persistent choices that alter places, people, and later missions. 3) Archaeological mystery built from conflicting evidence. 4) A submersible that serves as mobile base, home, and exploration tool. 5) Companions who remember events, hold convictions, and can genuinely break with the player.

Tone and experience

The experience blends wonder, isolation, political intrigue, moderate cosmic horror, and survival drama. Not every creature is an enemy: some are ecosystems, some are interlocutors, and others should be observed from a distance.

02. Scope and experience targets

Target duration

The central story route is approximately 100–150 hours for players who follow main objectives and explore moderately. A route rich in faction and side content may reach 200–250 hours. A highly completionist campaign can exceed 300 hours. Distinct campaigns should offer exclusive content rather than force artificial repetition.

Supporting 300 hours

Content combines seven acts, six major factions, around twenty recruitable companions, vertical regions, emergent missions, systemic ruin investigations, submersible construction, reputation chains, world events, and divergent endings. Final duration must be validated through pacing prototypes and telemetry; empty travel must not inflate playtime.

Integrity rule

The game should not claim that every choice changes everything. Each major choice alters a defined set of variables: territorial control, trust, resources, living characters, player knowledge, ecological state, or ending access. Consequences may be subtle, but players should be able to recognize them when investigating.

03. World and depth zones

Vertical structure

The map is organized into connected basins, caves, canyons, abyssal plains, and trenches. Depth is more than a number: it changes light, pressure, temperature, wildlife, communications, navigation, materials, and survival strategies. Unlocked shortcuts reconnect visited regions so scale does not become repetition.

Zone 1 — Shelf (0–500 m)

The starting and learning zone. Human stations, docks, workshops, markets, small colonies, and smuggler routes. The hub city of Port-Lume introduces the conflict between dependence on the Atlantic Consortium and the autonomy sought by Nereus.

Zone 2 — Blue Forest (500–2,000 m)

Bioluminescent kelp fields, artificial reefs, creature migrations, and communities that use luminous organisms for energy. Players learn to read currents, follow biological traces, and avoid disturbing territorial species.

Zone 3 — The Ruins (2,000–4,000 m)

Non-human architecture, machines responding to sound patterns, and inscriptions with multiple layers of meaning. Here the player finds the first evidence that human accounts of an Abyssal attack were manipulated.

Zone 4 — The Abyss (4,000–8,000 m)

Limited visibility, extreme pressure, abandoned facilities, and huge creatures. Equipment requires specialized maintenance. Communication with the surface is nearly impossible.

Zone 5 — The Trench (8,000–12,000+ m)

The final region, accessible through upgrades and specific decisions. The geology appears artificial in places. The Leviathan’s prison is revealed as a distributed structure, not a single door or cell. The descent is a narrative commitment, not merely a level check.

04. History before the game

The Pelagic Age

An ancestral civilization, called the First Ones, developed organisms capable of storing and transmitting energy and memory. They were not identical to today’s Abyssals; their society contained different lineages and philosophical conflicts.

The Original Leviathan

The Leviathan emerged from a biological technology designed to connect consciousness and ecosystems. The network grew beyond its creators’ control. To some, the entity was a catastrophe; to others, it was an emergent life-form being harmed by containment.

Building the Trench

The First Ones could not kill the entity. They built a prison distributed across geological cavities, living mechanisms, and resonance structures. It prevented the consciousness from expanding, but also caused suffering and ecological change.

The memory conflict

Survivors split. Some records called the event a war; others, containment; others, genocide. Accounts were altered over millennia. Modern Abyssals inherited incompatible fragments and do not know the whole truth.

Human arrival

Human colonies expanded in search of minerals, energy, and shelter. The Atlantic Consortium declared the ruins strategic assets. The Republic of Nereus claimed sovereignty. Helix Corporation began secret biological experiments. The Trench Order interpreted Leviathan signals as divine revelation.

05. Cinematic opening and character creation

Scene 0 — Darkness

Black screen. Three sounds: sonar, uneven breathing inside a helmet, and a distant voice that seems to travel through water. Voice: “Do not search for the city. Search for what the city is keeping asleep.” A bioluminescent flash cuts through the darkness. Hard cut to character creation.

Visual creation

Players customize face, body, skin tone, hair, marks, tattoos, scars, voice, optional pronouns, posture, and idle animations. Cosmetic options should not be locked by origin. Suits, helmets, lights, insignia, tools, and submersible paint can be changed later.

Origin — background choice

Former soldier: weapons experience, protocols, and security posts. Scientist: data, samples, and ancient mechanisms. Smuggler: contacts, illegal routes, and negotiation. Explorer: navigation, survival, and discovery. Colony native: local customs and infrastructure. Descendant of the First Ones: rare sensitivity to ancestral systems, but social suspicion and intrusive dreams. No origin is mandatory for completing the campaign.

Starting attributes

Vigor, Technique, Perception, Presence, and Knowledge. Players distribute a limited number of points and choose an initial specialization. Attributes unlock approaches rather than closing the story: a door may be hacked, negotiated open, forced, or bypassed through a flooded route.

Scene 1 — The contract

At Port-Lume’s dock, supervisor Dalia Venn offers the protagonist a contract to recover the Orpheus. The job is presented as rescue and data retrieval. The payment covers debt, equipment, and access to restricted zones. Dalia avoids explaining why the vessel was near a forbidden area.

Scene 2 — First descent

The player tests buoyancy, thrusters, sonar, suit integrity, and current reading. A damaged drone transmits a distress call, then repeats a sentence in a voice that does not match its log. The tutorial ends when a huge shadow crosses the beam without attacking.

06. Core characters

Protagonist

A player-created avatar whose history is not fully predetermined; origin provides context and tools. The dramatic question is whether the character turns knowledge into domination, protection, freedom, or transcendence.

Mara Voss — nomad captain

Pragmatic, witty, and distrustful. She commands the Peregrine and can become an ally, rival, or optional romantic interest. She despises governments that promise safety in exchange for obedience. She may leave if the player sells nomad communities to the Consortium.

Dr. Elias Sen — xenobiologist

Believes Leviathan consciousness is real and deserves moral consideration. His curiosity can make him underestimate risks. He interprets samples and may break with the player if sentient organisms are used as weapons.

Korr — Abyssal emissary

A non-human diplomat who questions his own species' doctrine. His language is learned through sound patterns, luminous gestures, and context. He is not a walking translator: Korr has political goals and may manipulate information.

Helena Rusk — Consortium officer

Disciplined, capable, and initially convinced human expansion is necessary to prevent colony collapse. She can become a reformist ally, an antagonist, or an authoritarian commander depending on the player's choices.

Nox — conscious organism

Found in an abyssal region. At first, Nox does not speak; it alters light, temperature, and small devices to respond. Trust grows through observation and care, not a dialogue meter. Nox may become a bridge to the Leviathan.

Dalia Venn — contractor

Introduces the opening mission. She is a Consortium agent but does not know the full operation. Later, it is revealed she authorized the mission to recover data that could clear her name over an earlier disaster.

07. Factions and goals

Atlantic Consortium

A corporate-military power controlling extraction, routes, and much of human infrastructure. Goal: centralize resources and keep ancient technology from rivals. Internal split: expansionists versus reformists.

Republic of Nereus

A confederation of independent cities. Goal: sovereignty and fair resource distribution. Its risk is fragmentation: free cities may become fiefdoms or fight over energy, water, and protection.

The Abyssals

A non-human civilization with traditions and internal disagreements. Official goal: preserve territory and prevent ruin exploitation. Some leaders prefer isolation; others want diplomacy; a military faction wants all humans expelled.

Order of the Trench

A religious movement interpreting the Leviathan as divine. Its members are not all fanatics: some find community and meaning in the Order. Leadership manipulates prophecies and may try to free the entity without understanding the consequences.

The Nomads

Mobile communities living on platforms and, in some cases, in symbiosis with enormous creatures. Goal: autonomy and safe routes. The player may help them form a league or sell them to territorial powers.

Helix Corporation

A research company focused on biomedical science and organism engineering. It claims to seek treatments and energy solutions. Its secret program attempts to copy the Leviathan’s neural network. Not every scientist knows the project’s full scope.

08. Gameplay systems

Exploration and navigation

Active sonar reveals geometry but can attract wildlife or expose the player’s position. Passive sonar is safer but requires echo interpretation. Currents and temperature are clues. Maps are built from found data and may contain deliberate errors.

Pressure, oxygen, and temperature

Survival should create tension, not constant micromanagement. The suit warns early, provides a safety margin, and supports upgrades. Death should not erase dozens of hours: recovery points, crew rescue, and gradual losses are preferable to arbitrary punishment.

Combat

Weapons include harpoons, pressure weapons, electrical devices, drones, improvised tools, and ancient technology. Fighting large creatures is risky, not universally optimal. Stealth, distraction, escape, negotiation, and behavioral study must remain viable.

Progression

Five skill branches: Survival, Engineering, Combat, Diplomacy, and Xenoknowledge. Specializations can be combined. Respecialization is available at selected facilities with a light narrative cost, without locking players into their starting choice.

Economy

Resources, parts, samples, and data change value as wars, blockades, and shortages evolve. Players may trade legally, smuggle, or influence supply chains. The simulation should prioritize readable effects rather than model every unit of cargo.

Submersible construction and upgrades

The Peregrine is mobile base, workshop, and social space. Modules include lab, armory, bunks, workshop, storage, sonar, drones, armor, and propulsion. Modules compete for energy and space. Exterior, lighting, paint, and interior are customizable.

Companions and trust

Companions remember key events. The system tracks trust, ideology, safety, promises, and personal boundaries. A companion may disagree without leaving; a break occurs when core values are repeatedly violated.

Dialogue and investigation

Players gather evidence and challenge accounts. Some dialogue options depend on evidence, not just attributes. It is possible to reach the wrong conclusion by trusting a biased source. The journal separates confirmed facts, hypotheses, and rumors.

09. Detailed story — Act I: The Descent (0–30 h)

Mission 1 — Recovery contract

Goal: accept Dalia’s contract and prepare the suit. Scenes: character creation; dock conversation; equipment inspection; choice of debt or personal motivation. This choice does not determine morality, but changes dialogue and some contacts.

Mission 2 — Echoes of the Orpheus

The player follows the signal into a canyon. They find recent wreckage and cut marks impossible for known human tools. A drone repeats a distress call from someone already registered as dead. The investigation teaches sonar and evidence reading.

Mission 3 — Survivor without a shadow

An Orpheus crew member is alive in an isolated chamber. They insist there were “two cities” in the same place. The player can rescue them, sedate and deliver them to a facility, or leave them behind to pursue the data. Each option changes trust and who controls the testimony.

Mission 4 — Port-Lume under pressure

Back in town, the player discovers power rationing. The Consortium blames Nereus saboteurs; residents blame industrial extraction. The player can investigate, sell evidence to a faction, or sabotage the generator to force negotiations.

Mission 5 — The listening door

In the ruins, a door responds to sound rhythms and light pulses. Brute force damages inscriptions; a scientific method preserves data; Korr, if recruited early through an alternate route, recognizes part of the pattern. The door opens a view of an immense structure beneath the rock.

Act I twist

The Orpheus was not simply lost: it was diverted to test an ancient machine’s response. The recovery contract was a cover. Dalia knew the vessel carried sensitive data but did not know the structure would respond to the human signal.

Act close

The player returns to the Peregrine with a fragment emitting pulses synchronized to sonar. Overnight, every monitor briefly displays the same impossible map. Nox has not yet been found; something appears to be watching the crew.

10. Detailed story — Act II: The Cities (30–80 h)

Mission 6 — Three versions of an attack

A human city claims the Abyssals attacked it. Korr offers the opposite account. A Helix file suggests an automated defense system fired first. The player must gather three independent pieces of evidence; an incomplete version can be released for political advantage.

Mission 7 — The price of light

In the Blue Forest, a colony depends on a bioluminescent species. Biomass extraction produces energy but destroys its habitat. The player can protect the species, negotiate controlled cultivation, support industry, or ignore the crisis. The decision changes regional wildlife and the economy.

Mission 8 — The captain and the blockade

Mara Voss asks for help breaking a Consortium blockade. The player may smuggle medicine, steal military parts, or negotiate passage. Violence reduces route security; diplomacy may expose nomad communities.

Mission 9 — Nereus Council

The player presents evidence before rival representatives. Strong evidence creates a commission; manipulated evidence empowers a faction and may discredit the protagonist. Peace is not guaranteed: the outcome depends on alliances and earlier scandals.

Mission 10 — The memory chamber

A ruin contains sensory records: images, sound, and emotional fragments. The player experiences an ancient scene without explanation. It can be read as an attack, escape, or attempted communication. Elias recommends preserving it; Helix offers payment to remove it.

Act II twist

Helix has been cultivating neural tissue derived from ancient samples. It did not create the Leviathan, but it is amplifying the prison’s pulses. The company believes it can use the network as an energy source. Orpheus data proves the experiments accelerated instability.

Act close

A tremor crosses three regions. Creatures abandon old routes, communications fail, and a city’s artificial sky goes dark. The player receives contradictory messages: the Order announces an awakening; the Consortium declares an emergency; the Abyssals close their borders.

11. Detailed story — Act III: The Ruins (80–130 h)

Mission 11 — The language of currents

The player learns to combine sound frequencies, light patterns, and symbols. Translation never produces a perfect sentence immediately; hypotheses have confidence levels. Misreading a warning can open a dangerous area or destroy a clue.

Mission 12 — The divided archive

Three facilities hold parts of a historical record. Each was controlled by a different faction. To reunite them, the player can negotiate, infiltrate, or seize the sites. The record reveals that the prison was built by a divided civilization, not a united people.

Mission 13 — Korr before his people

Korr is summoned to answer for collaborating with humans. The player may defend him, let him face the tribunal, or use his status as leverage. If exiled, a diplomatic route closes; if protected without hearing the Abyssals, part of the population may radicalize.

Mission 14 — The creature that does not attack

A huge creature blocks a canyon. It reacts to vibrations and appears injured by an extraction device. The player can kill it, repair the device, lure it away, or attempt contact. The choice changes the ecosystem and access to a passage.

Act III twist

Records show the First Ones disagreed about the Leviathan. One group wanted it destroyed; another defended it as an emergent consciousness; a third believed the network had already absorbed memories from the entire civilization. Every faction’s official history omitted different parts.

Key scene — Borrowed memory

Touching a preserved core, the protagonist sees an ancient city silently going dark. The scene does not confirm whether it is genuine memory, simulation, or current communication. If found, Nox responds with a pattern matching the protagonist’s heartbeat.

Act close

The player discovers the Trench coordinates. The descent requires three access keys, each obtainable through different routes: diplomacy, science, force, exploration, or trade. There is no single mandatory path.

12. Detailed story — Act IV: War (130–190 h)

Mission 15 — The Nereus incident

An explosion hits a station. Evidence points to an attack, but traces may have been planted. The player decides whether to deliver the evidence, investigate secretly, or use the incident to back a faction. War may begin immediately, remain limited to skirmishes, or be temporarily avoided.

Mission 16 — The besieged city

The player arrives at a city with only days of supplies. They can open an evacuation route, defend generators, negotiate with the besiegers, or take command. Priorities determine who survives: civilians, technicians, soldiers, or political leaders.

Mission 17 — Dalia’s trial

Documents reveal Dalia’s role in the Orpheus operation. She can be exposed publicly, protected in exchange for access, or helped to testify against superiors. If convicted, the Consortium loses stability; if spared without conditions, her guilt may become leverage.

Mission 18 — Crew fracture

A companion discovers the player concealed information that could have saved a community. The scene occurs aboard the submarine, intimate and without combat. The player may confess, justify the decision, offer restitution, or threaten the companion. The relationship may change permanently.

Mission 19 — The resonance field

Helix activates a prototype to stabilize the network. It reduces tremors for minutes but transmits a pulse that awakens creatures and causes failures in distant cities. The player can shut it down, take control, or redirect it.

Act IV twist

The Trench Order did not invent every signal. The Leviathan really does transmit patterns, but the leadership chose to translate “listen” as “free me.” This is political manipulation, not necessarily a complete lie.

Act close

War and ecological change spread. Some regions change: routes close, outposts are occupied, and refugees appear. The game must preserve alternate routes so a local defeat cannot make the campaign unwinnable.

13. Detailed story — Act V: The Abyss (190–240 h)

Mission 20 — Preparing the descent

The crew must adapt the Peregrine. The player chooses armor, silence, drones, lab capacity, or propulsion. Configuration should not make other choices impossible: replaceable modules and world-found solutions provide alternatives.

Mission 21 — The submersible graveyard

A region contains vehicles from different eras, all oriented toward the Trench. Records suggest some arrived and returned empty; others appear to have been dismantled from the inside. Exploration reveals clues about the prison and earlier expeditions.

Mission 22 — Nox finds a voice

Nox creates a light-and-sound pattern that systems partially translate: “it is not a cell; it is a wound.” This may mean the prison hurts the Leviathan or that the entity is hurting the world. Interpretation depends on gathered evidence.

Mission 23 — The geological heart

The player finds living mechanisms connected to rock plates. Destroying one opens a route but weakens the prison. Repairing it requires resources and may save regions while prolonging the entity's suffering. Diverting its energy is a third approach.

Mission 24 — Helix's offer

A corporate representative offers technology to protect the crew and control parts of the network. In return, they ask the player to take a living core to the surface. Acceptance opens a domination ending; refusal may lead to an attack, negotiation, or alternate scientific alliance.

Act V twist

The prison was not built only to keep the Leviathan inside. It also prevents a second, fragmented and potentially hostile consciousness from reaching the network. The First Ones could not separate the two entities without destroying their own civilization.

Act close

The player reaches the edge of the Trench. The crew hears the opening line again, now in the protagonist's voice. It remains unclear whether the entity learned to imitate them, is using their memories, or has always been sending a warning through time.

14. Detailed story — Act VI: The Truth (240–280 h)

Mission 25 — Two consciousnesses

The player assembles evidence about the Leviathan and the second entity. Records contradict one another because the First Ones documented different experiences. The player can build a balanced hypothesis or choose a dominant interpretation to persuade factions.

Mission 26 — Tribunal of the Deep

Human, Abyssal, and Nomad representatives meet if relationships permit. This is not an unavoidable exposition scene: representatives may refuse, send substitutes, or sabotage the meeting. The player presents evidence and proposes a plan.

Mission 27 — The cost of every solution

The three best-known solutions—kill, free, or control—have different costs. Killing requires destroying resonance nodes and may kill symbiotic species. Freeing requires evacuations and trust in an unknown entity. Control requires consent or coercion and places immense power in someone's hands.

Mission 28 — The choice absent from the map

If the player preserved records, maintained key relationships, studied the language, and avoided destroying certain cores, a fourth option becomes available: split the network into smaller parts, allowing consciousness to disperse without being enslaved or fully released. This path is difficult, imperfect, and does not guarantee everyone survives.

Act VI twist

The Leviathan is not innocent in a human sense: while expanding, it absorbed memories and erased identities. But it is not a simple villain either; it was created, wounded, and contained by civilizations that tried to use it. The second entity may be a predator, an automatic defense, or a dissociated part of the network. Evidence supports more than one reading.

15. Detailed story — Act VII: The Last Horizon (280–300+ h)

Approach scene

The Peregrine enters the central cavity. External lights go dark one by one. The player may turn off sonar to avoid detection, keep it active for navigation, or transmit a light sequence learned from the Abyssals. The crew reacts according to trust and ideology.

The final conversation

The entity does not appear merely as a boss monster. It speaks through echoes of characters encountered during the journey. If a companion died, their voice may appear as reconstructed memory, not confirmed resurrection. The player confronts versions of their own decisions.

Final choice

The game presents unlocked solutions, but no morality score. Each option shows known consequences, unknown risks, and who will be affected. The player can reconsider until beginning the irreversible action.

Epilogue

The epilogue shows changes to cities, ecosystems, government, culture, crew, and historical records. There is more than one ending scene: a sequence of vignettes depicts the world weeks and years later. The final record is written by a historian interpreting the protagonist’s actions—and may be wrong.

16. Endings and conditions

Ending 1 — The Guardian

Condition: keep the prison functional, reject industrial use of the network, and ensure a succession of guardians. Humanity continues, but a secret order inherits the burden. The protagonist may remain as guardian or vanish from the records.

Ending 2 — The Release

Condition: open the main nodes and accept evacuations. The Leviathan returns to the oceanic network. Many cities are abandoned; new life-forms appear. The outcome may be hopeful or disastrous depending on ecological preparation.

Ending 3 — King of the Abyss

Condition: control the technology and accumulate political or military power. The protagonist rules a new order. Short-term stability rises, but freedom depends on their will.

Ending 4 — War

Condition: escalate conflict, destroy evidence for peace, and militarize the technology. Humans and Abyssals enter a prolonged conflict. The final map shows borders, devastated zones, and underground resistance.

Ending 5 — Human Extinction

Condition: radical Abyssal alliance, infrastructure collapse, and failed human evacuation. Humanity does not literally vanish, but loses its major cities and survives in small, vulnerable communities.

Ending 6 — Human Empire

Condition: Consortium victory and appropriation of the network. Humans control the routes while creatures and Abyssals are displaced or persecuted. The epilogue shows unequal prosperity and repression.

Ending 7 — Revolution

Condition: weaken all central powers and support community structures. No faction rules the ocean. The transition is unstable, but cities negotiate directly.

Ending 8 — The New God

Condition: integrate the protagonist with the network. The character loses part of their individual identity and gains ocean-wide perception. The epilogue does not confirm whether this is transcendence, imprisonment, or symbolic death.

Ending 9 — Sacrifice

Condition: connect the protagonist to the stabilizing mechanism and refuse to transfer the cost to a community. The prison stabilizes; the protagonist is presumed dead. Fragmentary records hint that their consciousness may persist.

Ending 10 — The End of the Ocean

Condition: overload the network to prevent the second entity’s expansion. Vast ecosystems collapse and complex life retreats. Humanity survives in artificial habitats; this is the most devastating victory.

Ending 11 — The Truth

Condition: gather sufficient evidence, preserve witnesses, and release both consciousnesses without subjugating them. The epilogue reveals the Leviathan was not the only threat, but leaves the second entity partly unexplained.

Ending 12 — The Cycle

Condition: find temporal records, activate the repetition mechanism, and choose to restart the system. The final line—“We have been here before”—suggests previous civilizations also tried to change the cycle.

Systemic variations

Each ending has variants based on companion survival, dominant faction, ecology, public trust, technology dissemination, and lost cities. The production target should be 12 macro-endings with multiple epilogues rather than dozens of expensive scenes with no meaningful variation.

17. New Game+ and continuity

Campaign memory

New Game+ preserves cosmetics, discovery records, and selected upgrades, but not all power, to avoid breaking progression. The world may start in alternate states: a leader recognizes the player, a faction fears them, a city has been rebuilt, or a route is closed.

Knowledge as a variable

Players who already know the truth may recognize symbols earlier, but NPCs still require evidence. Player knowledge should not automatically replace in-world proof. Some narrative shortcuts require the character to find a record again.

No mandatory canon

A sequel can import a state summary: factions, cities, companions, final solution, and technology. Without a save, players choose a set of historical events or accept a default state.

18. Side quests and emergent content

The Cathedral Whale

A colossal creature carries ruins attached to its back. The player can remove structures, study the symbiosis, help the creature, or force their way into the ruins. The choice affects the Nomads and a migration route.

The Surface-less Beacon

A station transmits a light that seems to come from above despite having no line of sight to the surface. Inside, the player finds messages from people not yet born—explainable as fraud, prediction, or a network phenomenon.

The Voting City

A colony uses an algorithm to distribute resources. It is fair on average but always sacrifices the same district. The player may reform, shut down, expose, or sell the system.

The Bone Garden

A mineral-rich area is also a burial ground for a sentient species. Miners want extraction; spiritual leaders demand protection. The game does not mark one answer as good: each has social and material costs.

The False Map

A cartographer sells safe routes that lead into traps. Investigation reveals they are trying to halt a faction’s advance. The player can expose, recruit, or use them against their buyers.

Dynamic events

Convoys disappear, species change routes, outposts are occupied, biological outbreaks emerge, and characters travel. Events follow clear rules and a production budget; they must not destroy core missions or punish players for being elsewhere.

19. Interface, accessibility, and quality of life

Contextual HUD

Oxygen, suit integrity, pressure, and power remain discreet until needed. Sonar, compass, and depth can be rearranged. A minimal HUD option is available.

Investigation journal

The journal separates observed facts, testimony, hypotheses, and conclusions. Players can flag contradictions and link clues. The game does not automatically solve every mystery.

Accessibility

Adjustable subtitles and text size, contrast, remappable controls, color-vision modes, reduced flashes and camera shake, navigation assistance, and difficulty settings. Audio puzzles have visual equivalents.

Pacing

Long exploration needs safe points, reliable saves, unlockable fast travel, and ways to reduce backtracking. Long duration must not require marathon sessions without breaks.

20. Art direction and audio

Visual identity

Humanity: salvaged metal, industrial signage, cables, and functional lights. Nereus: modular architecture and communal gardens. Abyssals: curved structures, translucent materials, and meaningful luminous signals. Ruins: familiar geometry at the wrong scale, without excessive ornament.

Color and lighting

The ocean must not become one monochrome blue. Biomes use distinct contrasts: bioluminescent greens, mineral blacks, volcanic orange, sediment white, and human signal colors. Darkness must remain legible and navigable.

Sound

Audio is part of navigation. Sonar, vibration, animal song, hull creaks, and silence are clues. Music is restrained and dynamic; giant creatures do not always receive boss themes. A city’s soundscape changes after war or collapse.

21. Narrative architecture and state data

Persistent variables

Faction reputation; individual trust; city state; territorial control; ecological health; prison stability; validated knowledge; companion survival; regional resources; irreversible decisions.

Consequence rules

Every main mission must define: variables changed, missions opened or blocked, expected reactions, immediate consequence, and delayed consequence. Minor choices may receive a later line of reaction; central decisions must change scenes, systems, and epilogues.

Avoiding fake choices

Do not offer three options that lead to the same scene with no perceived difference. If the plot must converge, vary the route, cost, allies, resources, or historical interpretation. Plot convergence must not erase what the player did.

Scope control

Build a vertical slice with one city, one ruin, one companion, one faction, and one ecological dilemma. Test whether a decision remains understandable 5–10 hours later before expanding to six regions.

22. Pre-production plan

Phase 1 — Discovery (8–12 weeks)

Define the core fantasy, pillars, target audience, platforms, preliminary budget, technical risks, and scope limits. Deliverables: product vision, risk map, references, and paper prototypes.

Phase 2 — Systems prototype (12–20 weeks)

Build underwater movement, sonar, pressure, basic combat, creature interaction, and mission state. Prove the ocean is interesting without constant markers.

Phase 3 — Vertical slice (6–9 months)

Produce Port-Lume, part of the Blue Forest, the Orpheus mission, one companion, and a choice with a visible later consequence. Include representative art, audio, UI, dialogue, and performance.

Phase 4 — Scaled production

Only after the vertical slice should production of more regions, factions, and content be approved. Prioritize modular kits and systemic variations so every hour does not require a new cinematic scene.

Teams and disciplines

Systems design, narrative, level design, gameplay engineering, AI, narrative tools, environment art, characters, animation, audio, UI/UX, accessibility, QA, localization, and production. Team size depends on visual ambition, technology, and target platforms.

Major risks

1) Enormous scope. 2) Branching narrative cost. 3) Repetitive underwater navigation. 4) Expensive creature AI. 5) Bugs in persistent states. 6) Unrealistic 300-hour promise. Mitigations: prototypes, modularity, automated state testing, fast routes, and pacing metrics.

23. Checklist for the next stage

Narrative

Character bible; First Ones timeline; fully scripted main missions; decision matrix; ending specifications; glossary of terms and names.

Design

Region map; skill trees; equipment tables; survival specification; economy; combat rules; creature AI; submersible progression.

Production

Cost estimate per region; staffing plan; schedule; QA plan; acceptance criteria; localization strategy; accessibility plan.

Approval criterion

The project advances to full production only if the prototype proves that exploration, clue interpretation, and decision-making are fun without relying on raw content volume.

24. Thematic close

Thesis

The ocean holds life, history, and power; danger comes from the unknown and from the desire to control it. The player receives no simple moral answer because civilizations built their identities around incomplete memories.

Core line

“You do not choose the ending. You build the world that makes that ending possible.”

Last image

After the credits, a light turns on far beyond the known map. Sonar records a response that matches neither the Leviathan nor the second entity. The signal ends before it can be decoded.